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Black nomads of the Sahara

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In Tibesti, the ritual [sadaga](#) is performed either in the gardens or in the [mochidi](#) of the villages: square enclosures of dry stones with three openings. Each small, built-up area that borders a palm grove has its own.

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When the moment has come to perform the big [sadaga](#) for rain, it is at the [mochidi](#) that the people gather. Each furnishes dates to buy the ox which the most pious Muslim slaughters at dawn. Standing in a circle, the others watch and are silent. While the sacrificial animal is being skinned, cut up, and the liver cooked in embers (in the meantime the other pieces are roasted at the fire), the women arrive from the valley in converging lines. They carry [tibi](#) of barley or wheat, milk and butter in baskets and bottles of finely plaited straw. When the last ones have arrived, everybody turns toward the [mochidi](#). There, in front of the [tibi](#) that has been massed together, each person, man or woman, opens his receptacle of milk and pours the contents of its on his little pile with which he makes his offering. They crowd into the narrow enclosure and jostle each other somewhat. Quarrels break out between women and the

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men try to calm them, while they themselves become very excited. There is no composure in this ceremony in which each one is concerned first of all with his own actions. Little by little, people leave the mochidi, some not bothering to go through the openings. Then groups form to gossip or joke. Finally, the people gather together and the leader recites the invocations, his hands in the pose for the recitation of the fatiha. The others imitate him more or less carefully. It ends with a chant in which the word fatiha recurs.

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At the end, groups form and this time the drum is beaten. If there have been no recent deaths, the women dance. When the cooking of the animal is finished, the men volunteer³⁸⁴ to divide it up. They distribute the pieces equally. People hold out their little baskets and equal parts are given to each man, a small part to the old women and to the children, while the young women get nothing even though they are present. Each one carries off his portion which he will eat in the evening at home. In former times, people ate on the spot, but now this would be contrary to Islamic ways.

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If the sadaga has been performed to produce rain and has not been effective, it is repeated somewhat later, and it is begun again when clouds gather.

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